



▶ Shirt Tales

❶ A school dropout himself, K.P. Ramasamy's empathetic leadership in providing free education to KPR Mill's factory workers, predominantly women, has created a loyal and skilled workforce—a big plus in the labour-intensive textiles sector

❷ The company's strategic expansion to higher-margin yielding garment exports a decade ago, under his guidance, has aided higher revenue and profits

❸ The firm's vertically integrated yarn-to-garments set-up gives it an edge over peers in profit margins and delivery timelines

❹ It has leveraged off-seasons of the cyclical textile business for capacity expansion, while growing revenue and profits

❺ The company boasts of a strong financial record, showing stability and resilience

▶ **ROLE MODEL** K.P. Ramasamy, Chairman, KPR Mill

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Nothing about Ramasamy reveals that he is one of India's 100 richest people, with a staggering net worth of ₹19,000 crore; not his no-frills office; not the plain white shirt he is mostly seen in. Under him—a farmer's son who was forced to drop out of high school—the company has become adept at turning challenges into opportunities.

He pioneered free education up to Class 12 for factory workers, mainly women dropouts. Over 27,000 women workers have successfully completed their studies, with some even obtaining MBAs. Many have now taken up positions in various industries, such as nursing and IT,

while others are advancing in their careers at KPR Mill. In an industry grappling with skilled-labour shortages, Ramasamy, fondly known as "Appa" (or father) to his vast workforce, has earned immense goodwill.

A cyclical textile-and-garment business doesn't always adhere to capacity expansion plans. If you start building a new factory when the demand is good, chances are that the scenario will have reversed when you finish it. "The right time to start a project is during the dull phase—that's our plan," Ramasamy quips. The rationale is that when the project is completed, demand may have returned, allowing the market to readily ab-